Draft - expert review pending

Note: This unit is complete and passes the platform's automated checks, but it is not reviewed yet. So, treat its sources and claims with care. You are encouraged to report errors and provide feedback.

Unit 1 assessment

Unit summary

This unit built a single idea across five topics: **critical thinking is the habit of judging a piece of reasoning against a set of clear standards, and it is a skill that can be trained rather than a personality you have or lack.**

- Topic 1.1 gave the is/is-not picture: critical thinking is not criticising, not general scepticism, not a fixed trait.
- Topic 1.2 named the standards you apply to any piece of reasoning: clear, accurate, precise, relevant, deep, broad, logical, fair.
- Topic 1.3 named the barriers that stop it, grouped by where they come from: the self, the group, the wish, the assumption.
- Topic 1.4 gave the basic units of reasoning - statement, claim, issue, argument - and a decision path for telling an argument from a mere claim or an explanation.
- Topic 1.5 described the characteristics of a critical thinker and showed what they look like in a teacher's daily work.

Together these give you a usable professional habit: when you meet a claim about teaching or learning, you can examine it against the standards, watch for the barriers, and tell whether you are looking at an argument or only an assertion.

Summative assessment

Multiple-choice questions (MCQs)

Choose the single best answer for each question.

1. *(Remember)* Which of the following best describes critical thinking as defined in this unit?
    - A) Finding fault with other people's ideas
    - B) Doubting every claim until it is proven
    - C) Judging a piece of reasoning against clear standards
    - D) Being naturally intelligent and well read
2. *(Remember)* How many standards for reasoning did this unit introduce?
    - A) Four
    - B) Six
    - C) Eight
    - D) Ten
3. *(Understand)* A teacher says, "My pupils failed the test, so the test must be too hard." Which barrier does that reasoning most show?
    - A) Wishful thinking
    - B) Egocentrism - blaming the test rather than examining the teaching
    - C) Group conformity
    - D) Fairness to opposing views
4. *(Understand)* Which of the following is an *argument* in the logical sense used in this unit?
    - A) "Attendance is poor on Fridays."

- B) "We should start the week on Tuesday."
- C) "Practical work helps pupils learn because it lets them see the idea, not only hear it."
- D) "May I see the textbook?"

5. *(Apply)* A colleague says, "We should adopt this method because the trainer said it raises results." Applying the *accuracy* standard, what is the most important question to ask?

   - A) Whether the trainer has visited our school
   - B) What evidence supports the claim and how "raises results" was measured
   - C) Whether other schools have adopted it
   - D) Whether the trainer is senior enough to be trusted

6. *(Apply)* A head teacher says, "We have always set homework in grade 1 and parents expect it, so we will continue." Which barrier does that reasoning most show?

   - A) An unexamined assumption
   - B) Group conformity and an appeal to habit rather than evidence
   - C) Wishful thinking about results
   - D) Egocentrism about the head's own schooling

7. *(Apply)* Which pair best captures the difference between a claim and an argument?

   - A) A claim is true; an argument is false
   - B) A claim asserts something is true; an argument gives a reason to support the assertion
   - C) A claim is spoken; an argument is written
   - D) A claim is short; an argument is long

8. *(Apply)* A teacher evaluates a workshop claim by asking, "What is the evidence, and has it been tested with pupils like mine?" Which characteristic of a critical thinker does this best show?
    - A) Willing to say "I don't know"
    - B) Open to evidence and precise about what is claimed
    - C) Dismissive of outside ideas
    - D) Wedded to the first view
9. *(Apply)* "Critical thinking means being sceptical of everything." Why does this unit reject that definition?
    - A) Because scepticism is a character flaw
    - B) Because critical thinking accepts well-supported claims and challenges weak ones, rather than doubting everything
    - C) Because teachers should never question anything
    - D) Because scepticism is the same as critical thinking
10. *(Apply)* A teacher reads a textbook suggestion and asks, "Does this example fit my pupils, and is this the only way to teach this idea?" Which two unit ideas is she combining?
    - A) The standards and the barriers
    - B) Critical reading of material and the habit of a critical thinker
    - C) Claims and explanations
    - D) Egocentrism and group conformity

Restricted-response questions (RRQs)

Answer each question in the space indicated.

1. *(Understand)* In two sentences, explain the difference between critical thinking and merely criticising, using the idea of *standards*.

2. *(Understand)* Name the four sources from which barriers to critical thinking come and give one example of a barrier from each.

3. *(Apply)* A colleague says, "These pupils cannot do group work; they are too young." State whether this is a claim, an issue or an argument, and give one reason for your answer.

4. *(Apply)* Take the claim **"Setting no homework will improve pupils' wellbeing."** Apply the *accuracy* and *relevance* standards to it in one sentence each.

5. *(Analyze)* A teacher says, "I know my method works because my results are always good, and I have been teaching for fifteen years." Identify the barrier it most shows and explain why in two or three sentences.

6. *(Apply)* Name three characteristics of a critical thinker from Topic 1.5 and, for each, give the opposite habit it replaces.

7. *(Understand)* Explain the difference between an argument and an explanation, using the idea of a *reason meant to support* versus a reason that only accounts for how something came to be.

8. *(Apply)* A staffroom claim is made: "We should not change the exam format because parents expect the old one." Apply the *depth* standard to this claim in one or two sentences.

9. *(Analyze)* Look at this reasoning: "Mind-mapping improves writing - a senior teacher said it worked in her class." Name the barrier it most shows and explain in one or two sentences why accepting a claim because of who said it is a barrier.

10. *(Apply)* A textbook says, "Pupils learn best when they discover ideas for themselves." State one question a critical-thinking teacher would ask before adopting this, naming the standard the question applies.

Extended-response questions (ERQs)

Answer each question in a short paragraph (80-140 words unless stated otherwise).

1. *(Analyze)* This unit defined critical thinking as "judging a piece of reasoning against a set of clear standards" and rejected the idea that it means "being sceptical of everything." Compare these two definitions and explain, with a classroom example, why the unit's definition is more useful for a teacher.

2. *(Evaluate)* A head teacher says, "We should adopt activity-based learning because children learn better when they are doing, not just listening." Evaluate this reasoning against *three* of the eight standards from Topic 1.2. For each standard, state whether the claim meets it and give one piece of reasoning.

3. *(Analyze)* A teacher says, "We have always streamed our pupils by ability and our results are good, so there is no reason to change." Analyse this reasoning: name the barrier it most shows (Topic 1.3), explain why, and state which characteristic of a critical thinker (Topic 1.5) would lead someone to question it.

4. *(Evaluate)* Here is a short argument: **"Morning assembly should be shortened. The first period after assembly always loses ten minutes, and the term timetable is already too full to spare them."** Evaluate this reasoning: state whether it is a claim or an argument, name the conclusion and the reason, and judge whether the reason actually supports the conclusion.

5. *(Create/Evaluate)* A workshop trainer, a textbook and a senior colleague all tell a teacher that a new method "raises results by 30 per cent." Taking a single piece of reasoning from one of these sources, evaluate it against *two* standards (Topic 1.2), name the barrier it most shows (Topic 1.3) and explain what a critical-thinking teacher would do before adopting the method (Topic 1.5). Draw on at least three topics from the unit.

Answers and marking guidance

This section is for self-study. Try every question above before you look back at the keys below.

MCQ answer key

1. **C** - Judging reasoning against clear standards. A describes criticising, B describes general scepticism and D confuses critical thinking with intelligence, all rejected in Topic 1.1.
2. **C** - Eight (clear, accurate, precise, relevant, deep, broad, logical, fair).
3. **B** - Egocentrism: the teacher locates the cause in the test (outside the self) rather than examining the teaching. A would be believing a wished-for result; C would be following the group's view.
4. **C** - An argument: it asserts something is true (practical work helps) *and* gives a reason meant to support it (because it lets them see the idea). A is a mere statement, B is a mere claim, D is a question.
5. **B** - The accuracy standard asks what evidence supports the claim and how the key phrase was measured. A, C and D appeal to the source rather than the evidence.
6. **B** - Group conformity and an appeal to habit/others' expectations rather than evidence for the policy itself. The reasoning rests on "parents expect it" and "we have always".
7. **B** - A claim asserts; an argument gives a supporting reason. A is wrong (claims are not always true); C and D confuse the logical distinction with length or medium.
8. **B** - Open to evidence and precise: she asks for evidence and whether the claim holds for pupils like hers. A is not yet in view; C and D are the opposite of what she is doing.
9. **B** - The unit rejects blanket scepticism because critical thinking accepts well-supported claims and challenges weak ones. A is wrong (scepticism is not a character flaw); C and D are false.

10. **B** - She is reading the material critically and showing the habit of a critical thinker (questioning rather than adopting on trust). A names the wrong pair; C and D do not fit.

RRQ model answers and mark schemes

1. **Model:** Critical thinking judges a piece of reasoning against standards such as clarity and accuracy; merely criticising means finding fault, often without applying any standard. **Marks (2):** 1 - names standards as the basis of judgement; 1 - distinguishes that from fault-finding.

2. **Model:** From the self (egocentrism), from the group (group conformity), from the wish (wishful thinking), from the assumption (unexamined assumptions). **Marks (4):** 1 for each correct source with a recognisable example.

3. **Model:** It is a claim. It asserts something is true ("these pupils cannot do group work") but offers no reason to support it. **Marks (2):** 1 - correctly identifies it as a claim; 1 - gives the no-reason reason.

4. **Model (accuracy):** The claim needs evidence that wellbeing actually improves and a measure of "wellbeing". **Model (relevance):** The claim must bear on the actual question being asked - wellbeing, not for example attainment. **Marks (2):** 1 per standard correctly applied.

5. **Model:** Egocentrism. The teacher judges by her own results and experience rather than by independent evidence, and treats her own success as proof the method works. **Marks (3):** 1 - names egocentrism; 1 - explains it as self-judgement; 1 - ties it to the text ("my results", "fifteen years").

6. **Model:** Open to evidence (replaces being wedded to a first view); fair to opposing views (replaces dismissiveness); precise (replaces vagueness); willing to say "I don't know" (replaces guessing). Any three. **Marks (3):** 1 per correct characteristic-with-opposite.

7. **Model:** An argument offers a reason *meant to support* a claim; an explanation offers a reason that only accounts for how something came to be, not evidence that it is true. **Marks (2):** 1 - distinguishes support from accounting; 1 - uses the "meant to support" idea.

8. **Model:** The claim does not get to the real question - it rests on what parents expect rather than on whether the exam format is the best way to assess pupils. **Marks (2):** 1 - applies depth; 1 - identifies the surface-level reason given.

9. **Model:** It most shows an appeal to the source (a form of group conformity / unexamined assumption). Accepting a claim because of who said it is a barrier because the truth of a claim does not depend on the speaker's status. **Marks (2):** 1 - names the barrier; 1 - explains why source-based acceptance is a barrier.

10. **Model:** A question such as "What is the evidence that pupils learn best this way, and has it been tested with pupils like mine?" applying the accuracy standard. **Marks (2):** 1 - asks an evidence-based question; 1 - names the standard.

ERQ rubrics

1. Definition comparison

Criterion	0-3
Names both definitions	0-1
Explains why the standards-based definition is more useful	0-1
Gives a concrete classroom example	0-1 (**Analyze**: example shows the standards being applied)

2. Standards evaluation

Criterion	0-3
Three standards named and applied	0-1
Specific reasoning for each judgement	0-1
Judgements are defensible from the text	0-1 (**Analyze**: cites the claim's wording)

3. Barrier analysis

Criterion	0-3
Barrier named correctly	0-1
Justified with specific reasoning from the text	0-1
Names the opposing critical-thinker characteristic	0-1 (**Analyze**: ties barrier to characteristic)

4. Claim-or-argument evaluation

Criterion	0-3
Correctly classifies and gives reason	0-1
Names conclusion and reason accurately	0-1
Judges whether the reason supports the conclusion	0-1

5. Integrative source evaluation

Criterion	0-4
Two standards applied to the chosen reasoning	0-1
Barrier named and justified	0-1
States what a critical-thinking teacher would do	0-1
Draws on at least three topics	0-1 (**Analyze**: integrates standards, barriers and teacher habit)

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